

Writing your own melody

There are always new melodies to be written. Many things can provide inspiration—a mood, the words of a poem, or the sound of an instrument.

Steps and leaps

Most melodies have a mixture of steps and leaps. Moving from one note to another that is a whole note or half note away is known as a step. A leap is when you jump from one note to another that is further away. Scales have steps, and arpeggios have leaps. The mixture of steps and leaps helps to give a melody its shape, or contour.

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- ◀ 92–93 What is a tune?
- ◀ 94–95 Phrasing and phrase marks
- ◀ 96–97 Types of phrases
- ◀ 108–109 Analyzing melodies

▽ “The Mulberry Bush”

This nursery song has a clear, memorable melody with a distinctive rhythm and a satisfying shape, mixing steps and leaps.

■ Leaps ■ Steps



Rhythm

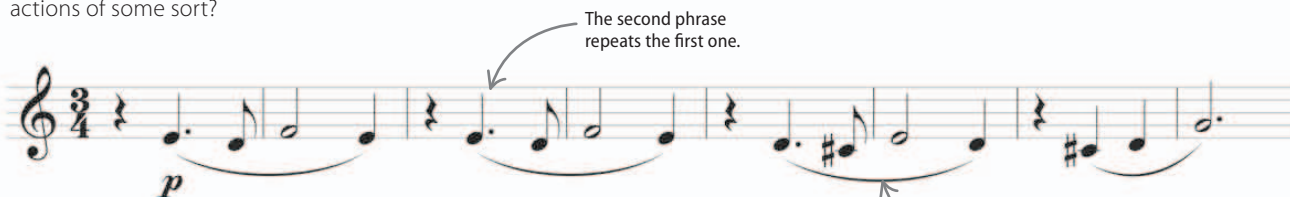
Rhythm, like melodic contour, gives shape to a tune. The rhythm will be determined by various things. Is your melody fast or slow? What is the meter? Does the melody have a distinctive rhythm? Does the rhythm help to bring out the phrase structure? Perhaps the words suggest a strong rhythm. Or is the music intended for dancing or actions of some sort?



The 2/4 time signature sets up a punchy rhythm.

△ “Heads, Shoulders, Knees, and Toes”

The rhythm, with its long and short notes, gives a distinctive character to this well-known children’s action song.



The second phrase repeats the first one.

△ Waltz from *Swan Lake*

This dance from the ballet *Swan Lake* by Tchaikovsky has a distinctive rhythm, influencing how the dancers move.

The third phrase has the same shape and rhythm, but different pitches.